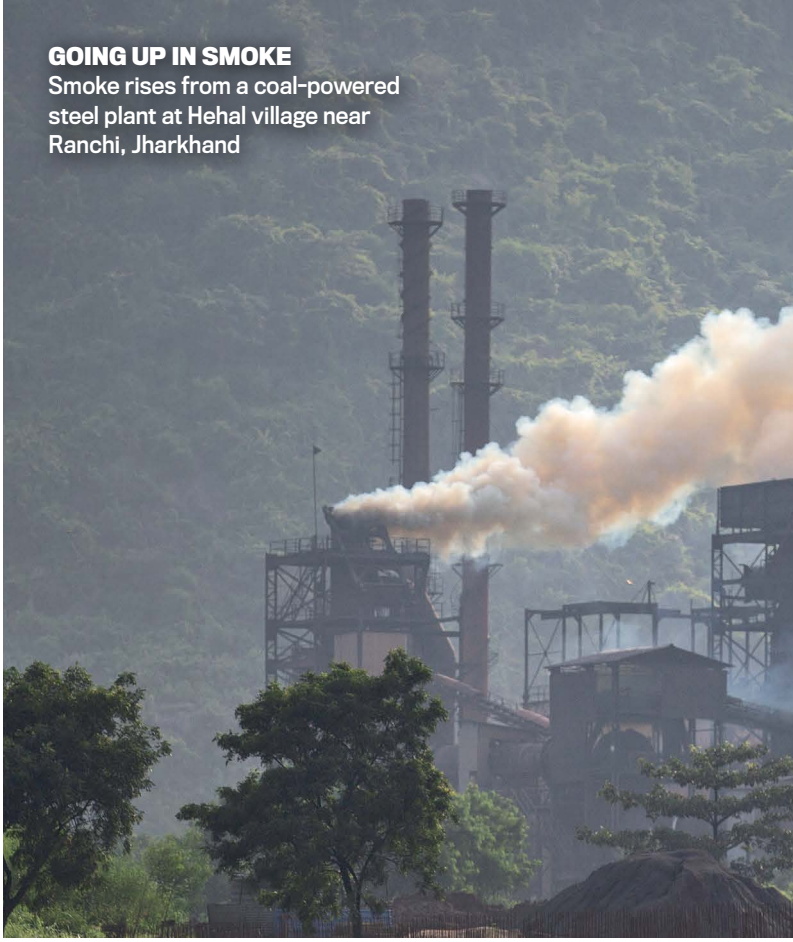
Driven by a host of government subsidies and measures, including the Faster Adoption and Manufacturing of (Hybrid &) Electric Vehicles (FAME-II) policy with a budget of Rs 10,000 crore and the expansion of charging infrastructure, sales of EVs topped the one million mark in less than nine months in 2023, according to media reports in September. So far, more than 1.1 million vehicles have been supported under FAME-II. But there's still a long way to go, as EV adoption remains slow—their sales comprised a measly 5.6 per cent of total vehicle sales in FY23. Poor charging infrastructure, higher price tags compared to conventional vehicles in the same category and poor sales among fleet operators may be to blame.

In the longer term, though, there is no better solution than to encourage the public in big cities to use the mass transport system to reduce the number of individual vehicles on the roads. Bengaluru, for instance, is looking forward to the completion of the metro rail. Currently, the Bengaluru Metro network covers 73.81 km and another 101.25 km is under construction. More and more cities are also looking at EV options to augment their public transport fleets. Delhi, for instance, is looking to induct 950 electric buses. This August, the Centre launched the PM ebus Sewa, with the aim to procure 10,000 e-buses in 169 cities.

Meanwhile, there are several ways in which pollution from commercial vehicles can be curbed. These include switching to cleaner fuels like CNG, using low-emission vehicles in fleets, periodical inspection and maintenance of vehicles, including cleaning of their tailpipes. The other option is to use commercial EVs or go for hydrogen generated through green sources. In fact, stakeholder consultation has started on creating a policy framework for hydrogen fuel in India. In 2018, the Centre exempted battery-operated vehicles, and vehicles driven on methanol or ethanol from getting a permit to carry passengers or goods. The Centre has also notified the blending of gasoline with methanol in order to reduce vehicle emissions. Transport minister Nitin Gadkari had set an ambitious target of a 10 per cent reduction in the import dependence of oil and gas by 2022 from the 2014-15 levels through these methods. ■



GOING UP IN SMOKE
Smoke rises from a coal-powered steel plant at Hehal village near Ranchi, Jharkhand

POWER PLANTS

The Dark Truth

Coal-based power plants may meet most of our energy needs, but in the long term it is imperative that India explore renewable energy sources

India has a difficult choice ahead of it. While advanced nations are pushing for phasing out coal altogether as a fuel source in order to keep global warming under check, India can't turn the tap off easily. Coal-generated power meets 75 per cent of the country's electricity needs currently. At present, India has 267 thermal power plants that generate over 230 GW of power, of which close to 200 GW is generated from coal-fired plants and the rest from oil and gas. The Union power ministry has announced that another 18 thermal power plants (of which 17 will use coal as fuel) are coming up in different parts of the